

Oxford summative assessment formats

All 40 formats with direct-evidence design strategies

Purpose. Use this reference when selecting or strengthening an Oxford summative assessment format. The strategies focus on making the intended knowledge, reasoning, judgement, process or performance visible. No format automatically proves authorship or eliminates unauthorised assistance. Where AI could materially obscure the capability being assessed, use more than one proportionate source of evidence.

Assessment format	Assessment type	Assessment task	Description	Direct-evidence design strategies
Written Exam	In-person, timed invigilated	Essays	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject.	Controlled, device-restricted and invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of independent performance when they are effectively and accessibly implemented. Further strengthen by using unseen questions requiring synthesis of teaching-unit-specific content; designing prompts that demand personal critical positioning rather than description; and rotating question banks annually. Ensure invigilation procedures comply with Oxford's Examination Regulations.
Written Exam	In-person, timed invigilated	Multiple choice questions	Students are required to select the correct answer from a list of possible answers.	Controlled, device-restricted and invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of independent performance when they are effectively and accessibly implemented. Design items at higher Bloom's taxonomy levels (application, analysis, evaluation) rather than factual recall alone. Use scenario-based or case-vignette items. Rotate question banks annually to prevent re-use.
Written Exam	In-person, timed invigilated	Short-answer questions	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence, provide a short descriptive answer, or annotate a diagram.	Controlled, device-restricted and invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of independent performance when they are effectively and accessibly implemented. Embed teaching-unit-specific diagrams, data sets, or unseen primary sources in the exam paper. Require annotation, justification of reasoning, or application of concepts to novel scenarios. Vary question parameters annually.
Written Exam	In-person, timed invigilated	Problem / computational question	Students present written solutions to problems, explaining their rationale for the approach(es) taken.	Controlled, device-restricted and invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of independent performance when they are effectively and accessibly implemented. Require written justification of method choices alongside calculations. Vary numerical parameters, boundary conditions, and problem scenarios annually. Include questions requiring conceptual explanation of why a given approach is valid.
Written Exam	In-person, timed invigilated	Unseen translation	A writing task that assesses competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Controlled, device-restricted and invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of independent performance when they are effectively and accessibly implemented. Select passages from restricted or unpublished corpora where possible. Require a translator's commentary on stylistic and linguistic choices to make meta-linguistic awareness and decision-making visible.
Written Exam	Online, timed, invigilated	Essays	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject.	Where online invigilation is approved and accessible, use appropriate examination-platform controls and contingency arrangements; do not assume they eliminate access to other devices or services. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, the assessment setter must declare that AI use is prohibited. Rotate question banks and use teaching-unit-specific prompts; randomise question presentation across students where the platform permits.
Written Exam	Online, timed, invigilated	Multiple choice questions	Students are required to select the correct answer from a list of possible answers.	Where online invigilation is approved and accessible, use appropriate examination-platform controls; do not assume they eliminate unauthorised assistance. Randomise question order and answer options per student using item banking. Design application-level, scenario-based items. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI as prohibited and enforce via examination platform settings.

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Written Exam	Online, timed, invigilated	Short-answer questions	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence, provide a short descriptive answer, or annotate a diagram.	Where online invigilation is approved and accessible, use appropriate examination-platform controls and clear contingency arrangements. Randomise questions from a bank; embed teaching-unit-specific or newly released data directly in the question paper. Require justification of responses. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI as prohibited and ensure platform settings enforce this.
Written Exam	Online, timed, invigilated	Problem / computation questions	Students present written solutions to problems, explaining their rationale for the approach(es) taken.	Where online invigilation is approved and accessible, use appropriate examination-platform controls and clear contingency arrangements. Vary numerical parameters or problem scenarios per student where the platform allows. Require written justification of methods alongside calculations. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI as prohibited with platform enforcement.
Written Exam	Online, timed, invigilated	Unseen translation	A writing task that assesses competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Where online invigilation is approved and accessible, use appropriate examination-platform controls and clear contingency arrangements. Select passages not in public corpora where feasible. Require a translator's commentary on linguistic and stylistic choices. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI as prohibited and enforce via examination platform settings.
Written Exam	Online, open book, timed (up to 3 hours)	Essays	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject.	Open-book conditions make AI potentially accessible. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, the assessment setter must declare AI permissions clearly in advance. If AI is prohibited, redesign prompts to require: synthesis of named teaching-unit-specific sources; engagement with specific tutorial or seminar arguments; and a stated personal critical position with justification. Advise students to work offline where possible.
Written Exam	Online, open book, timed (up to 3 hours)	Short-answer questions	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence, provide a short descriptive answer, or annotate a diagram.	Embed teaching-unit-specific, recently published, or unpublished primary sources directly in the question paper. Require annotation of provided passages or application of teaching-unit-specific frameworks specific to the supplied material and teaching context. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions clearly in advance.
Written Exam	Online, open book, timed (up to 3 hours)	Case study response	Students respond to a real-world problem or challenge; this may involve material released in advance which the student has the opportunity to review and prepare notes on.	Design cases using novel or hyper-localised scenarios grounded in specific supplied evidence and disciplinary context. Embed data, documents, or stimulus material within the exam paper so responses must engage directly with provided content. Require students to articulate their reasoning explicitly. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy.
Written Exam	Online, open book, window (2 or 3 day)	Essays	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject.	Extended window significantly increases risk to assessment validity. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, clearly declare AI permissions before the window opens. If AI is prohibited, mitigate by: personalising prompts to individual students' tutorial portfolios; requiring a reflective process note or annotated bibliography submitted alongside the essay; specifying engagement with teaching-unit-specific or unpublished sources; and, where feasible, adding a brief oral follow-up component.
Written Exam	Online, open book, window (2 or 3 day)	Short-answer questions	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence, provide a short descriptive answer, or annotate a diagram.	Use multi-part questions requiring a consistent thread of reasoning across all answers, making piecemeal AI use less effective. Embed teaching-unit-specific materials, data, or unpublished sources in the paper. Require explicit justification of reasoning. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy.
Written Exam	Online, open book, window (2 or 3 day)	Case study response	Students respond to a real-world problem or challenge; this may involve material released in advance which the student has the opportunity to review and prepare notes on.	Use novel, locally contextualised scenarios that require direct engagement with specific supplied evidence and context. Require students to identify the limitations of generic AI-generated analysis, or to critically evaluate AI outputs as part of the task where AI use is permitted. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy.
Written Exam	Online, open book, long duration (1, 2 or 3 days)	Essays	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject.	Longest exam window: highest risk to assessment validity among written exam formats. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, clearly declare AI permissions in advance. If prohibited, require: a reflective process commentary; engagement with teaching-unit-specific or unpublished sources; and submission of an annotated plan or outline. Consider an accompanying oral follow-up component to verify individual understanding.

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Written Exam	Online, open book, long duration (1, 2 or 3 days)	Case study response	Students respond to a real-world problem or challenge; this may involve material released in advance which the student has the opportunity to review and prepare notes on.	Require primary data collection, fieldwork, or engagement with confidential or localised material that the student must obtain and interpret directly. Include a critical evaluation of AI-generated analysis as part of the response where AI use is permitted. Require a reflective process section. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	Take-away or take-home essays	Essays written after teaching has been completed and in response to a list of questions or titles released at a scheduled time. Students typically have around a week to select title(s) and complete their work.	Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions clearly before the assessment window opens. To strengthen resilience: personalise titles to individual students or cohort-specific material; require an annotated bibliography with reflective source notes; design prompts requiring engagement with unpublished or recently published sources and requiring direct engagement with the supplied evidence; consider a brief oral viva on the submitted work; and require a drafting process log.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	Case studies	Students find, select, and argue for solutions to a real-world problem or challenge, and either write up or orally present their findings.	Design cases using real, localised, or novel problems specific to the teaching context. Require submission of process documentation (research notes, initial analyses). Include an oral presentation or defence component. If AI use is permitted for specific tasks, require a formal declaration per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	Practical reports	Concise documents used to communicate the outcomes of an experiment or small-scale project.	Tie the report to specific, original experimental data submitted alongside it (raw data files, lab notebooks, supervisor sign-off on data collection). Require a methodology justification section explaining choices made during the practical. If AI is permitted for data visualisation or write-up support, require a formal declaration per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	Poster assessments	A form of visual communication which requires students to concisely summarise and prioritise information and/or ideas.	Require a live oral defence or Q&A; at the poster presentation, to elicit and assess the student's individual understanding in real time. Include original data or primary research evidenced on the poster. Require a reflective process statement. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	Business plans and design proposals	Documents which set out to persuade potential funders of the feasibility and profitability of a new product or service, and how this will be achieved.	Require a live oral pitch or defence before examiners. Embed a client brief or scenario specific to the teaching unit that AI is unlikely to have been trained on. Require process documentation (drafts, research notes, client communication). Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions; if AI is used for specific tasks (e.g. financial modelling), require a formal declaration.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	Translations	Assess competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Select source texts from restricted, unpublished, or recently published corpora. Require a translator's commentary explaining linguistic and stylistic choices, making the student's meta-linguistic reasoning and choices visible. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions clearly in advance.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	Dissertation / Thesis	Extensive pieces of work based on supervised independent research or investigation. The title and focus are often developed by the student. Often completed at the culmination of the degree programme.	Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, supervisors must declare AI permissions for the specific work. Build in regular supervision with documented process evidence (meeting logs, iterative drafts). Require engagement with primary sources, original fieldwork, or novel data. A viva voce examination provides the most robust verification of individual understanding. Require an AI use declaration in the final submission per Oxford's academic conduct regulations.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	Extended essays	A longer essay written on a topic of the student's choice. Can be written in response to pre-set questions, or on a title the student has developed. Students usually receive limited supervision and may be entitled to feedback on draft work.	Personalise titles in collaboration with supervisors to ensure specificity to the student's own research. Require a process portfolio (research notes, annotated bibliography, drafts). Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions clearly; if permitted for specific tasks, require a formal declaration in the submission. A brief oral follow-up may be appropriate.

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Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	Mini-projects and structured projects	Students are challenged to address more open-ended questions, extend a known result, or work with an industry partner on a problem. Mini-projects are typically released after teaching is completed; structured projects run over a longer period with supervision.	Require submission of lab notebooks, computational code, or process logs demonstrating iterative problem-solving. Regular supervisor check-ins and milestone reviews build process evidence. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions; if AI coding or analysis tools are permitted, require formal declaration and critical evaluation of outputs.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	Fieldwork, site, museum and industrial visit reports	Assess students' learning through fieldwork, a site or museum visit, or an industrial visit. Generally presented in a clearly structured format.	Tie the assessment to a specific physical experience and require relevant contemporaneous evidence and reflection. Require: dated field notes or observation logs; photographic or material evidence of attendance; and personal critical reflection on the experience. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions for the write-up phase.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	Portfolio	A collection of shorter pieces of work chosen by the student to demonstrate their competence and interest in a particular area.	Require a reflective commentary on the selection and development of pieces, explaining the student's learning trajectory over time. Include pieces tied to specific practical sessions or tutorials. Require process evidence (drafts, iterations). The curation rationale and personal reflection are harder for AI to replicate authentically. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	Research papers and articles	Work follows the format and conventions of a published paper or article in the field, often following the brief of a particular journal.	Require primary research, original data, or a novel argument developed through independent inquiry. Build in a peer review simulation involving oral feedback. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions; if used for specific tasks (e.g. literature searching, data visualisation), require formal declaration and critical evaluation of AI outputs.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	Business plans and design proposals	Documents which set out to persuade potential funders of the feasibility and profitability of a new product or service, and how this will be achieved.	Require iterative process documentation across the project period, supervision or mentoring logs, and an oral pitch or defence. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions; if AI is used for financial modelling or design, require a formal declaration and critical evaluation of outputs.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	Translations	Assess competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Select source texts from restricted or unpublished corpora. Require a substantial translator's introduction and commentary demonstrating meta-linguistic reasoning. Supervision logs provide process evidence. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions for both the translation and commentary phases.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Practical tests and simulations	Various	Students are observed conducting a series of defined tasks within a specified period of time, and are assessed against a set of pre-determined criteria.	Observed practical performance provides direct evidence of physical, procedural and real-time decision-making capability. Vary scenarios across cohorts and years; use randomised task sequences. Assess using standardised rubrics with observer verification. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare any relevant AI permissions (e.g. AI-assisted diagnostic tools) if applicable to the discipline.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Oral presentation	In relation to a case study, research project or paper	Assesses knowledge and understanding, as well as the ability to communicate orally and visually. The audience may include peers and members of the department. May be performed live or pre-recorded.	Live delivery with real-time examiner Q&A; can strengthen evidence of individual understanding and communication. Where pre-recorded formats are used, add a mandatory live follow-up session. Vary prompts across students. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions for the preparation phase (e.g. AI slide-generation tools); if permitted, require a formal declaration.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Viva voce and interviews	In relation to a dissertation or thesis	Oral examination of a student's understanding of submitted written work and its wider implications. The format may be formal and structured or less formal and dialogic.	A well-designed oral examination can provide strong direct evidence of individual understanding in real time. Design questions that probe beyond the submitted text into wider implications, spontaneous application, and personal intellectual development. Use unpredictable follow-up questions. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare any AI permissions relating to the submitted work under examination.

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Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Performances, exhibitions and displays	Musical performance	Assesses practical application of understanding and knowledge. Allows students to communicate their creative practice to wider audiences.	Live performance can provide strong direct evidence of the assessed practical or artistic capability. Individualise programme selection or include improvisatory elements requiring artistic choices. Where pre-recorded performances are accepted, add a live oral commentary or defence. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions for any composition or arrangement work accompanying the performance.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Performances, exhibitions and displays	Exhibition of created work	Assessment of original creative work exhibited for an audience.	Require a process portfolio (sketches, drafts, iterations, studio notes) demonstrating individual creative development. A live oral commentary or defence at the exhibition directly verifies individual understanding. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, declare AI permissions for any AI-assisted creation tools; if permitted, require a formal declaration of AI-generated versus student-created elements.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Objective Structured Clinical Examinations (OSCEs)	Various	Students undertake a series of tasks in sequence to demonstrate a range of skills and competencies in authentic contexts.	The real-time, multi-station and physical format can provide strong direct evidence of the assessed clinical capabilities. Strengthen by varying station scenarios annually; using standardised patients who can adapt dynamically to student responses; and including stations assessing professional communication and clinical reasoning under time pressure. Declare any AI permissions relevant to preparatory simulation tools per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Aural examination	Various	A series of exercises that assess listening skills, typically in relation to language or musical competency.	Live or closely invigilated conditions can provide direct evidence of listening and spontaneous response. Vary stimulus material (musical passages, spoken texts) annually. Include improvisatory or spontaneous response tasks. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, AI use must be declared as prohibited and enforced via examination conditions.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Oral examination	Various	A series of exercises that assess verbal skills, typically in relation to language competency.	Live, controlled oral conditions can provide strong direct evidence of spontaneous language production. Include unpredictable prompts requiring live linguistic production. Vary topics and registers annually. Per Oxford's current AI use in summative assessment policy, AI use must be declared as prohibited. Where pre-recorded elements are used, add a mandatory live follow-up component.

Implementation must remain consistent with current Oxford Examination Regulations, the University's AI use in summative assessment policy, local faculty or programme guidance, accessibility requirements, reasonable adjustments and student workload expectations.